

Pakistan's Federal Legislature

Introduction

Pakistan's federal legislature is called the Parliament. It is composed of the President, the National Assembly, and the Senate. The President plays a constitutional role by summoning and ending parliamentary sessions. The National Assembly is the lower house, while the Senate is the upper house. Together, they make and pass laws for the country.

National Assembly

The National Assembly has a total of 336 members. Out of these, 266 are general seats filled through direct elections. 60 seats are reserved for women, and 10 are reserved for non-Muslims. Members are elected for a five-year term, unless the Assembly is dissolved earlier. The house is led by the Speaker, who conducts sessions impartially. In the absence of the Speaker, the Deputy Speaker performs the role. The National Assembly also plays a central role in the formation of the federal government. The Prime Minister comes from this house.

Senate

The Senate is the upper house of Parliament. It ensures equal representation of provinces. It has 96 members in total. Each province elects 23 senators and the federal capital elects four. Pakistan's federal capital is Islamabad. Senators serve for six years. Every three-year election held to replace half of the members. The Chairman of the Senate leads the house and performs the duties of the President when the office is vacant or when the President is unable to act.

Legislative Process

The passage of a law requires approval from both houses of Parliament. A bill must be passed by the National Assembly and the Senate before it goes to the President for approval. Without the President's signature, a bill cannot become law. In cases of disagreement between the two houses, a Mediation Committee is formed. It consists of members from both sides to reach a settlement.

Cabinet and Accountability

The National Assembly elects the Prime Minister. The Prime Minister heads the federal cabinet. Cabinet members must be part of Parliament. Federal ministers can come from the Senate but no more than one-quarter. This arrangement ensures that both houses remain connected to the executive branch and hold it accountable.

Conclusion

Pakistan's Parliament is bicameral, consisting of the National Assembly and the Senate. The National Assembly represents the population, while the Senate represents provinces. They make laws and oversee the government under the constitutional role of the President. This structure balances population-based and provincial interests at the federal level.

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